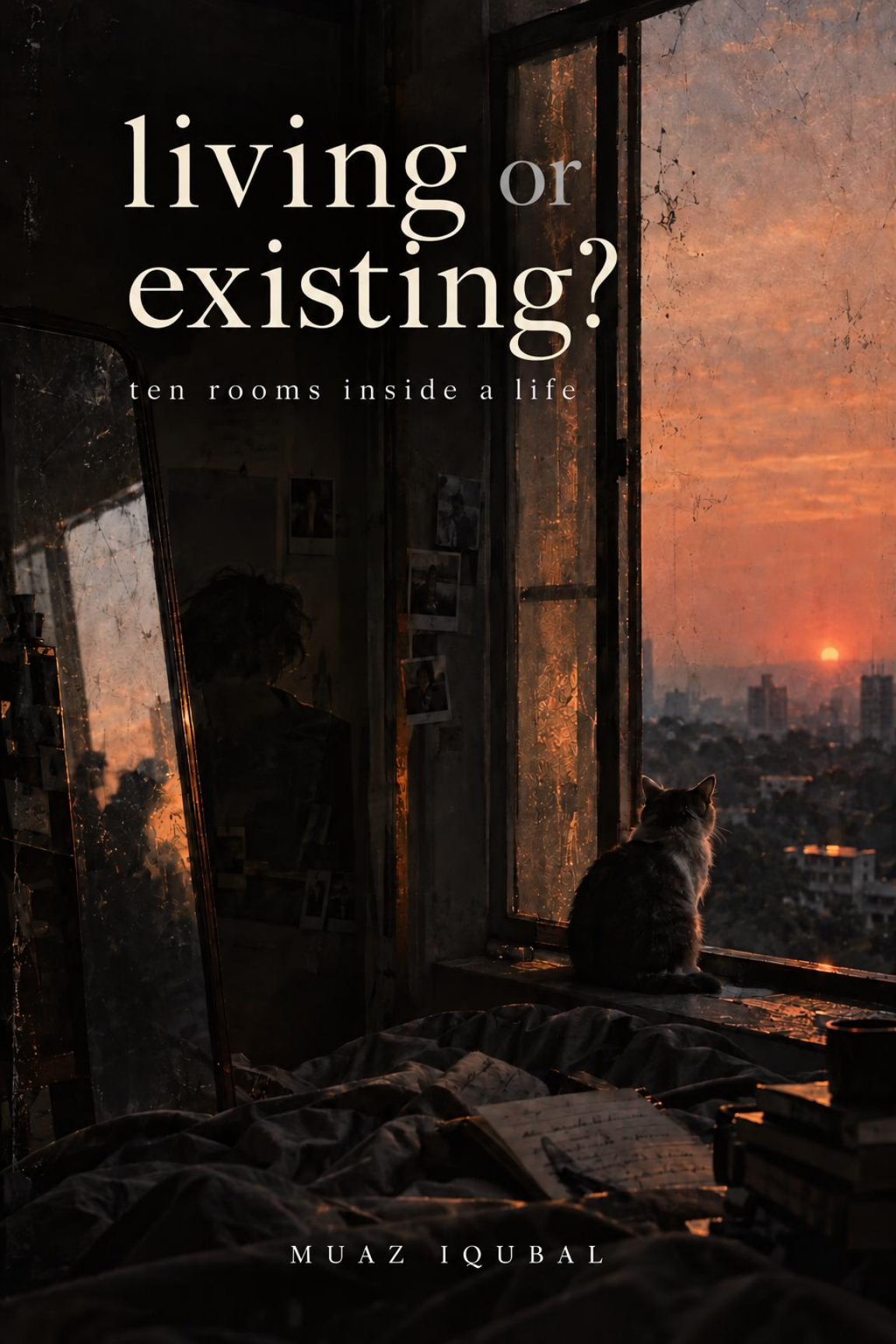

living or existing?
ten rooms inside a life
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First assembled edition

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I — Bound by the curse to constantly change ; a vagabond

Why do I have no home? Where do I stay?

I can't stay — because if I did, the permanent feeling of being caged would slowly tear apart my existence. I tell myself I am free. For once, I feel like I am. But am I really?

Am I truly free, or am I only acting as if I am? Has the very idea of freedom enslaved me? The more I chase it, the more I feel trapped by it. I've seen people who are bound by responsibilities, by places, by labels — yet somehow, they seem freer than I do. It makes me wonder: is freedom just a state of mind? I don't want to believe that. Because if it is, maybe I've never really been free at all.

I tell myself, "I am not a slave. I am free." That's what I think every time someone asks where I live. But the truth is, I have no home. I'm not tied down by four walls, not breathing in the same recycled air day after day. And yet, I'm still bound — bound by the idea of freedom.

If I were truly free, wouldn't I be able to stay in one place without feeling suffocated? Why does the thought of permanence make me feel imprisoned?

I stand in the midst of the railway tracks, heading to a new destination.

This emptiness consumes me. Strangely, everything I've lost feels like everything I once hoped for. It's hard to tell whether I've gained anything at all. If I kept losing everything I once had, was there ever anything gained? Why do I find myself stuck in a whirlwind of memories I never truly lived?

Maybe I am a slave — not to society, not to others — but to my own thoughts. Maybe I've deluded myself into believing I'm escaping a world that made me feel trapped, when in fact, I've built the prison in my own mind.

Was it the world that made me feel enslaved, or was it me?

I can't remember a time I felt truly happy or truly sad. I just feel… empty. Like a vessel — just collecting experiences, feelings, memories — never quite living them. And when this vessel finally breaks, where will I go?

I keep telling myself I have no home. That I'm not confined by any walls. That I am free. But then I walk through empty streets, trying to convince myself I believe it. I look up and see two birds playfully chirping, flying with ease, and for a moment… I imagine what it would feel like to be free.

Did the birds go back to their nests? I ask myself as I question the idea of my existence, as it washes away everything I was.

Once again, I begin to change — never truly living what it felt like to be authentic.

Just a vessel of fragmented memories, bound by the curse to constantly change, never to be found again.

II — Life's Cruelest Joke and the Illusion of Free Will.

Looking out the window, cigarette in hand, I prepare to ash it while the glittering towers outside leave me both amused and unsettled. Amid the brightness, I notice a faint yellow glow: a mother carrying the lifeless body of her daughter through the night. Around her, people laugh and drink, intoxicated by their own pleasures, blind to the tragedy unfolding beside them. My ears begin to ring. It feels as though I have fallen into a dark void, suspended within the brightest lights. My eyes, heavy with tears like an overflowing waterbed, turn inward as I begin to question my existence.

What if I had been born elsewhere? Would my fate have already been sealed the day I entered the world? Would my ambitions, my dreams, and my smile have been labeled, priced, and limited by forces beyond my control? In the grand scheme of things, in this finely tuned machine we call life, I cannot help but laugh bitterly at nature's most merciless joke. And what is that joke? It is "life" itself, the cruel gift of being born, a sin only a few can bear. For the amusement of the ringmaster, we were given what he calls "free will," yet punished endlessly for using it.

To be praised is to feel acknowledged, but history shows us again and again that it is the merciless, not the kind, who rise to power. History, written by victors, erases the cries of the defeated. Yet paradox remains: there are no victors without the vanquished. Every breath we take is paid for by another's last gasp. When the ringmaster wills it, it becomes. And those who dare to question? Silenced, crushed, extinguished by the privileged those who fan the flames of power by snuffing out the light of others.

We, slaves to power, cloak ourselves in the illusion of free will. But was it ever truly ours? Across the revolutions of earth, across heaven and hell, mankind has sought the same thing: power, wealth, and the pleasures of flesh. Perhaps we were fine-tuned not for freedom, but for hunger for lust, for envy, for dominance. We multiply out of fear of extinction, yet remain divided, united only by the pursuit of power.

So tell me again do we truly possess free will? Or are we merely bound to the whip of the ringmaster, dancing for his amusement, longing for his praise?

III — All While I Was Burning Myself Away.

My mind a headspace of thoughts, a cog of wheels all intertwined but running independently. I wonder: where do we derive our consciousness? Is it a predetermined build-up of mindfully crafted genetics? If yes, what part of myself do I own?

I think and think, clueless, standing in a darkening room as my thoughts grow darker. I dive deeper, think deeper, feel deeper — mindlessly, almost frantically. My eyes widen, feeling lost; a wave of hollow breeze follows. Silence. My thoughts start shutting down.

Walking down every road I take, I notice none were crafted beautifully, but thrown together, with every path connecting to one and the same place. Where does it connect? Each path always led to an uncertain darkness, unsure of its heading, as if representing the heedless and agonizing attempts of improvisation. Each path is filled with despair and a hollow attempt at a pretense of direction a path leading nowhere but to a sense of loss.

I walk these roads alone, wondering where I am lost. Who was I before I started? Who am I now? I feel everything deeply but lack the remorse — a vessel meant to hold but one that leaks

with every pour.

Walking further, I notice dead plants. Were they overwatered, or did they receive any water at all? Bricks fallen, collapsed buildings. I think: who built these? Why are they broken? I feel lost. Why is it dark, yet I burn? A heat scorches me from deep within. I feel enraged. Why? Is it because the plants are dead, or the buildings collapsed? Or is it because no one cared to notice while they existed?

I see a new path. I diverge; the cogs move again. I see it being built with the same flowers and the same buildings. Will these fall too, I ask myself? I dare not answer, never looking at the new path again.

Numb from these frail tries, I walk down a single road, not realizing what I am doing.

My thoughts, my paths, and my words represent nothing but an empty vessel.

I sit beside a pit of water, thinking about the dead plants. Oh, how I wish I could go back to every path I saw and water them. Just once, to see if they could have lived. Would they look any different from how they were before? It isn't long before the scorching heat dries every drop from the pit, and I wonder: did I think too long, or was I just desperate?

"...Oh, so very desperate," I whisper to myself, while my cogs oh, so fragile melt away.

I experience a blissful darkness. Every path burns away before my very eyes while I stand alone on these crowded paths. The last of my images fades away as I reminisce about my constructor's face — the one who built every path I could ever

look forward to.

All while I was busy burning myself away.

IV — I've collected failures like a collector collects his debts

It's cold outside. It's red everywhere. I feel tired as my eyes begin to shut, the white making the red seem more beautiful than it truly is. The metallic smell is fading now. My wrists feel numb as the sharp pain slowly dulls. Darkness closes in, wrapping around me as I sink into the sadness of the mess I've created — one last time. "It'll be a mess," I whisper to myself. No one will ever get the redness off the carpet. I should have worn black, not white. What would Mom — my smile fades along with my consciousness. Regret. Nothing good ever came from my living. Sadness and disappointment, a constant state of self-victimization. I strayed from the paths where I once saw light and surrounded myself with darkness until I became it. Once thought to be a creator of light, I destroyed everything I built — a terrorist of my own world. Grief reminds me why I'm here, weighed down by burdens I could never escape. I remember Mom doing my hair, Dad bringing my favorite food. Tomorrow there will be no disappointment. Perhaps they'll finally be free of the burden I've been. Maybe their faces will learn to laugh again, without fear of me taking it away. What I once took, I now return with this final act of mockery. The joke is on me this time — the clown who lived a life of becoming one.

Memories fragment; there's too little time to let them sink, though they feel like an ocean I'm drowning in. I remember every meal I shared with them. When was the last time I ate with anyone, I ask myself. I've turned bitter. Everything that once made me happy now feels like an unnecessary weight. Even my cat — the only peace I ever had — ceased to exist the day I learned to appreciate him. What good ever comes from living? I remember coming home from university with my stomach twisting, whispering, "I don't feel so good." I looked for the little ball of fur who loved me regardless, who loved me despite the loser I'd become. He was gone. Missing. Frantic, but calm, I told myself it wasn't the first time. Hours passed, and I aged with every breath. Midnight came, and he still hadn't eaten. I wished for rain; he always came back with the rain. He didn't. As if mocked by fate itself, I found him near the sewers — my beloved furball lying still, his little paws stiff, his nose red as always, but this time the red was cold. Everything in me gave up that day. The anchor of my existence had turned to mud. Buried. What were his last moments like? A sharp pain pierced my chest — it was over. Each day after, I tried to forget. Tomorrow became nothing but a shallow promise, yet we still set alarms, hoping it might give us another chance. I stopped setting alarms.

My eyes are tired — from the permanency of failure. I've collected failures like a collector collects his debts. The smiles I once gathered became a factory that manufactured grief. My very existence has turned into nothing but sorrow. The mirror now stands covered in black cloth; I cannot bear to face it. The anchor of failure has made this vessel too heavy to witness — buried before it could enter the casket. The body that once

carried a beautiful conscience now crawls with worms and maggots. The dead don't speak — but I did, every day. With every passing failure, the vessel gained another crack. How many more years before it finally breaks? The hands of the clock tick on, and somewhere, the divine master laughs.

V — The mirror that knows me.

Sitting by the window, I feel the street below ridicule my existence.
With every thought, I type and type, searching for a wish I can no longer name.
I miss who I was before, and in that remembrance, I am lost.

I tell myself I will figure everything out; it's too early.
Yet I feel it all slipping away — my heart, my consciousness — terrorizing this body I once believed was a gift from my creators.

Looking in the mirror, I see only failure.
Coping. Coping. COPING. COPING. COPING.
My head is no longer my safe space.

Withdrawals. My hands shake.
I used to rely on myself.
Now I don't even know where I am.

I am paralyzed by what's to come.
No one is certain of the future.
I try to improve. COPE. COPE. COPE.

Everything around me feels surreal —
stuck in a time loop, I feel alien, disconnected.
The pills hum beneath my tongue, blurring the edges of what's

real.
I am high, floating in an unreal alertness.

I am acutely aware of the distance
between what I was and what I've become.
My face, my body — disintegrate every thought of improvement,
expelling it with each failure.

I am a collector of failures,
moving from one collapse to the next,
never staying long enough to rebuild what I destroyed.

The red, warm liquid flows through me.
A slit. A gushing release — my consciousness spills out, covering me in red.
It is the warmth I longed for,
the burning passion that once kept me awake at night.

It's the red blanket I prepared for the long night.
A smile — the withering thoughts make me feel at ease.
It's blacking out.

Walking toward my grave, I stare into the mirror
that has always shown me my truth.
"You never had it in yourself," it screams.

The voice is larger than my shadow.
a voice that echoes beyond the hole I buried myself in.
The night doesn't end. Engulfed, I feel trapped.

When did it start — the maniacal laugh, the pain,
the sharp burning sensation, the metallic smell?

They say when you hit rock bottom, you can only look up.
I looked — the distance was far too great.

It's hot here.
I cry, pleading to return to when my creators fed me and I had no worries.
I am burning.

The punishment for birth only began once I left.
Nothing good ever came from my living.

Even the maggots cannot find a home in this vessel that was once loved.
No one will know that the person once loved
is the same one who now recoils at his own reflection.

The sight of myself makes me vomit the maggots that reside within.

Years from now, I will not exist.
Leaving nothing behind is the only gift I can give this world.

VI — My Beloved 4 legs

An emptiness filled by smoke inside left a yellow haze, while I smiled, for that threw me closer to where I belonged. Before a deafening silence and a gushing spill of my consciousness in red tainted the yellow haze into a deep red, yet slowly sinking into something ambiguous.

A mumbling of people. I smile for once.

I felt the warmth of care. The blue haze tainted with red — every consciousness bleeds before me. I see my beloved four legs on the other side.

He calls for me. It's bright; he finally realized his happiness. His body bore the wounds of hate and venom, for the venom was kinder to him than the disgusting poison of mankind.

His free will embodied, his desires achieved, and yet from the brightest corner he calls for me.

My body shivers in an ache. The bright yellow boundary is unsurpassable.

"I can't cross this," I yell.

I felt loved, yet I declined. I am not who I was supposed to be.

The museum of failures, tainted by an unlawful act of self-loathing and hatred. I smiled and walked away. I walked

towards what I myself had destined myself to.

I say my farewell to my beloved orange four legs, for he embodied himself and rested in what he loved. Yet a tear rolled down my eye, cleaning a part of me I forgot existed.

“Too late,” a blue figure whispers in my ear.

I smile, realizing for once I killed myself for the last time.

I turn my back and disappear into this red-black haze.

I smile, knowing my beloved four legs rests in a better place — my only relief.

~ Muaz

VII — Reflection

A haze of grey hovers over me.

My sight collapses, as though trying to kiss the ground.
I barely make it to the washroom as the room erupts into a cold roar.
The loss of one's conscience spreads through the room, yet everything around it remains perfectly harmonious.

I reach the washroom amidst the chaos.

A mirror.

Oh, so conveniently placed before my collapsing conscience.

With every uproar from the dead in the living room, my conscience sinks further beneath me.

Another sketch of white.

Another.

Until my trembling hands stop me before I can stop myself.

My heart races like a galloping horse fleeing an unseen predator.

My mind, however, is at ease.

An unsettling comfort.

A price so expensive that the vessel carrying this conscience falls like a crystal raindrop through the rainforest canopy.

Like a droplet resting on a leaf, it falls again and again before finally seeping into the soil.

Significant, some may say.

Insignificant, if not collective.

Another statistic.

Another number.

Another drop in the rainforest.

I collapse beside my reflection, one hand clutching my chest as though holding it together before it falls apart.

My mind fails to remember.

The seven minutes before the eternal fall are nothing but empty space —

much like the rest of my life.

A single tear escapes eyes that long ago stopped searching for success and instead learned to avoid failure.

Mediocrity became my closest companion.

Yet the relentless fear of becoming it pushed me toward a cliff few dare approach.

A walk beyond the very architects of my body.

My conscience, bruised by the very hands that once nurtured this healthy vessel. The fear of mediocrity reflected in their eyes carved a wound into my heart. A tumour unseen by many.

Hidden beneath the laughter.

Nothing entertained me anymore.

I was never who I claimed to be.

Boiling rage found the only thing that had ever reflected me without judgment or spite.

The mirror shattered.

Among the scattered shards of what had once shown me who I was —

free of hatred,

free of expectation —

I found a single fragment.

I held it before me.

A reflecting shard, like a key, I drove into myself.

The cages splintered.

Everything around me gave way while the room continued its relentless uproar, indifferent to what unfolded within it.

I went unnoticed, much like an existence that had been quietly rotting for years.

Yet the shard still reflected who I was rather than who I had been taught to become.

As the hours passed, the image before me grew clearer.

And I faded,

long before my eyes finally refused to open.

I wore a suit unfamiliar to me.

I would have preferred a hoodie.

My face was pale, softened only by the makeup painted upon it.

Buried beside my beloved four-legged companion,

I closed the eyes that had once been forced open beneath blinding lights.

The mirror understood me more than my own blood ever did.

The cruelest realization was not that the answers existed.

It was that they arrived only after the shard had broken the cages that held me.

Only after silence had replaced the roar.

Only after the reflection was all that remained.

VIII — A closing window.

I feel a void within me, growing slowly, like a window shutting, little by little.

Perhaps it is a missing purpose. But how could anyone live without purpose? Living itself is the purpose — the alternative is a rotting corpse beneath a rock, marked with nothing but a start date and an expiration date.

Just another date, a few years on.

The farther they walk from it, the more the memory blurs. The sorrows. The happiness. The memories themselves, fading into a deep, dark abyss.

The idea of remaining alive through memory alone ignites something furious within me. For someone who once wanted to die, I never wanted to go on living even in the memories of others.

The gloom around me fills the room — a thick haze of grey, now tinted red.

I snap back into my room. A show plays in the background.

I wonder where I left my keys.

My memory slowly fades. My burdened back gives out beneath its own weight.

I am as empty as the day I was born.

The paradox of being empty at two different signatures of time.

Once, that emptiness was called potential — an open vessel, waiting to be filled.

Now, it is simply failure.

Still an open vessel.

The lid is back on it, they say.

Writing about these dark voids is the only bridge between the two ends of my sanity before I fall into it forever — absorbed by everything around me while consciousness spirals beneath the crushing weight of reality.

The window is closing.

Ever so slightly.

IX — Human Behaviour Is Fleeting

Human behaviour is fleeting.

We spend our lives pretending that it isn't. We dress ourselves, build identities, chase money, chase love, chase recognition. We try to hold the world in our fists, as though enough control could make permanence possible. And yet beneath every attempt to live is the quiet knowledge that we are dying.

We simply choose not to acknowledge it.

Until death arrives.

There is something strange about standing before a dead body. The person who once moved, spoke, argued, desired, feared, laughed and struggled is suddenly reduced to stillness. The clothes remain. The face remains. The body remains.

But the person is gone.

A reflection in the mirror is suddenly nothing more than a dressed-up, slowly rotting body fighting against its own expiration with every contraction of the heart.

And perhaps that is what makes death so disturbing.

Not that the body stops.

But that everything we believed mattered continues without it.

Forty steps away from the casket, someone is already thinking about dinner.

A meeting has to be attended.

A message has to be answered.

Friends will eventually gather somewhere else.

Someone will laugh.

Someone will complain about work.

Someone will make plans for next weekend.

The world does not pause to mourn one of its inhabitants.

The person inside the casket fought for this world.

For what?

For another day.

Another achievement.

Another conversation.

Another morning.

Another chance to become someone worth remembering.

And then, suddenly, there is no next time.

The strangest part is the person who stays.

Everyone leaves eventually. The room empties. The voices disappear. The grave remains.

And someone stands there, looking at the place where a person has been buried, waiting for tears that never come.

He wonders if he is heartless.

But perhaps he isn't.

Perhaps his heart is simply too full.

Perhaps grief does not always become tears. Sometimes it becomes silence. Sometimes it becomes staring at the ground long after everyone else has gone. Sometimes it becomes remembering something insignificant—the way they spoke, the way they walked, the way they occupied a room—and realizing that you will never see it again.

And then, for a moment, something becomes painfully clear.

Life is not a possession.

It is a timestamp.

A brief interval in which death allows us to exist before it takes its turn.

Every heartbeat is not merely proof that we are alive.

It is proof that time is passing.

We spend so much of our lives trying to escape death that perhaps we forget to ask what we are doing with the time it has temporarily given us.

There is so much death surrounding us that life had to intervene and give it a rest.

And perhaps that is all life ever was.

Not the opposite of death.

Just its interruption.

Because death is not the final failure of life.

It is the certainty that gives life its shape.

The casket does not say that the person failed to live.

It says only that they reached the end of their attempt.

And eventually, every one of us will.

The dinner will continue.

The meetings will continue.

The laughter will continue.

Someone else will stand forty steps away.

And somewhere, someone will remember us.

Perhaps without tears.

Perhaps with a heart so full that it cannot produce a single one.

Until even that memory fades.

And then there will be nothing left but the timestamp.

The beginning.

The attempt.

The ending.

Life—

briefly interrupting death.